CHAPTER 49

LOCKDOWN

I have spent lockdown – like anyone else – worrying, walking around the house, wondering what to do. *Tailenders* comes into its own as we do quizzes and regularly meet up on zoom, it becoming its own universe of something to look forward to. We start a little charity – the Go Well Fund – to help with causes affected by Covid. At some point during the lockdown, as *Tailenders* rolls out from weekly episodes to constant communication with each other, I find myself watching the India vs Australia series late into the night, rolling my eyes while the rest of them make wild and inaccurate observations on almost every single aspect and session of the game. We begin to realise during lockdown that cricket – from each of our different perspectives – has meant so much to us. It's been a constant excuse for communication, for distraction when required, and for explaining our own lives to others when we needed it.

As we roll out shows twice a week, it becomes clear that many people across the country, or even the world, feel the same thing. It's becoming symbolic for the condition of the world to move through a summer where pitches are vacated and nets are unused. It also lands in a more meaningful way to me as it asks me: what has it meant to play cricket for England for so long? I begin to meditate on the privilege of being a vessel for which people channel their lives through, especially as time extends and my life becomes measurable through theirs. I hadn't stopped to think that babies might be born and loved ones lost with Test cricket as the backdrop or that whatever I've been doing inside a ground might also be reverberating outside in a lasting way.

As we use the time to reflect on what cricket has meant to all of us, and what we are going to use it for when (if) the world comes back, we build